difficulties that Castro's unyielding position on inspections was creating for the Soviets. They were therefore prepared to be flexible. Perhaps verification could be achieved by continuing flights over Cuba, or by Soviet agreement to supply lists of the weapons they were removing from the island. They wanted those weapons to include the ground-to-air SAM missiles, one of which had shot down the U-2 plane on October 28. Mikoyan refused to discuss the SAM missiles, as they were not covered by the Khrushchev-Kennedy exchange. He also rejected the suggestion of overflights as a tool of verification. "McCloy," Mikoyan telegraphed Moscow, "received a very firm response that the US has no right to overfly Cuba, and nobody can guarantee security of such unlawful flights."[6]

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MIKOYAN FLEW FROM NEW YORK TO HAVANA ON THE AFTERNOON of November 2. At the last moment, before leaving for the airport, he saw the list of weapons that Stevenson and McCloy considered offensive and expected the Soviet Union to remove from Cuba. It did not include SAM missiles but specified Soviet IL-28 bombers capable of carrying nuclear payloads and therefore considered offensive.

The list and covering letter were addressed to Vasilii Kuznetsov, the Soviet deputy foreign minister, who had accompanied Mikoyan to dinner the previous night. It turned out that Stevenson had forgotten to give the list to Mikoyan at dinner. Mikoyan suspected foul play and an attempt to slip in at the last minute one more requirement that was not part of the original deal. A few days later he would call the two Americans "pilferers," but for the moment he did not think much about what had happened. Ahead was the trying task of convincing Castro to go along with Khrushchev's proposal. The only trump card Mikoyan had in his pocket was Soviet willingness to endorse Castro's five points. Mikoyan made a statement to that effect before leaving New York. It turned out to be a smart diplomatic move.[7]

Fidel Castro hesitated until the last minute whether to honor Mikoyan by meeting him at the airport or to ignore him as a sign of displeasure with